schools; others hoped to save their boys from military conscription; and others were motivated by rumors that the government was going to send Cuban children to the Soviet Union and the Eastern bloc for training."[8]

Cuban immigrants were quite different from other Latin American immigrants in terms of their political identities. They began to arrive in the 1960s, just as the two largest Latin American immigrant groups, Mexicans and Puerto Ricans, were beginning to organize and explore what came to be a Third World, anti-colonial identity. The Cuban Revolution itself played an important role in the growth of Chicano and Boricua (Puerto Rican) ethnic identity and consciousness movements. Puerto Rican and Mexican immigrant activists developed an analysis of their people as colonized minorities in the United States, and elaborated an identification with anti-colonial struggles, including Cuba's Revolution. Yet the Cubans who were coming to the United States were those who opposed the Revolution. While the Cuban Revolution, and its protests against U.S. imperialism, found strong echo among Chicano and Boricua (Puerto Rican) activists, Miami's Cubans were working hard to overthrow the island's new political and social order.

Miami

The size, geographical concentration, and racial and social composition of the Cuban exodus meant that both Cuba and Miami – the prime destination for Cubans leaving the island – were transformed. Because the large majority of those leaving, especially in the first two decades of the Revolution, were white, Cuban Miami took on a light complexion, while in Cuba itself, the proportion of whites decreased. And while most Latin American immigrants remained in the lower socioeconomic sectors of U.S. society, Miami Cubans quickly rose to the top.

Alejandro Portes and Alex Stepick note the uniqueness of the changes in Miami: "A large American city [was] transformed so quickly that its natives often chose to emigrate north in search of a more familiar cultural setting." Rather than assimilating, Cuban immigrants established "a parallel social structure." The result was a process of